Saya Ikegawa

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Education

University of Washington Expected 2027
Ph.D. in Economics

Australian National University 2021
Master of Economics (with commendation)

Keio University 2016
B.A. in Economics

References

Fabio Ghironi (Dissertation Chair)
Paul F. Glaser Professor
Department of Economics
University of Washington
ghiro@uw.edu

Ellen McGrattan
Professor
Department of Economics
University of Minnesota
erm@umn.edu

Brian Greaney
Senior Research Economist
Federal Reserve Bank of Dallas
bgreaney@uchicago.edu

Research Fields

Macroeconomics; Public Economics

Job Market Paper

Unrealized Capital Gains Tax, Business Investment, and Wealth Inequality

Award: Grover & Creta Ensley Fellowship, University of Washington (2026).

Presented at: BSE Summer Forum (2026); Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco (2026); Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis (2026); Fourth Women in Central Banking Workshop (scheduled).

Abstract: Unrealized capital gains constitute a large share of wealth at the top of the U.S. wealth distribution and are concentrated in privately held businesses, yet they remain untaxed under the current realization-based capital gains tax system. Motivated by recent proposals to tax unrealized capital gains, this paper studies the welfare consequences of accrual-based (mark-to-market) taxation using a quantitative general equilibrium model of entrepreneurship and business sales. I find that accrual-based taxation applied to all households reduces private business production by 8%, aggregate output by 5%, and consumption-equivalent welfare by 3%, as reduced entrepreneurial entry outweighs the benefits of greater business turnover. In contrast, applying accrual-based taxation only to very wealthy households can reduce inequality and generate welfare gains of up to 1%. Targeting wealthy households, who are more likely to be incumbent business owners, limits entry deterrence, while reduced capital accumulation lowers equilibrium wages and encourages entrepreneurial entry among less wealthy households.

Work in Progress

Reassessing Japan's Fiscal Health with Ellen McGrattan and Adrian Peralta-Alva

Presented at: CEBRA Annual Meeting (2025).

Abstract: Japan faces considerable fiscal challenges due to rapid population aging. A large body of literature argues that *high* consumption tax rates or other significant policy changes will be required to stabilize public finances and maintain retirement, health, and long-term care systems. However, all existing quantitative studies *ignore* the role of *intangible capital*, thereby understating Japan's true wealth base and overstating the necessary tax burden. This paper re-examines the fiscal issue by incorporating newly compiled data on Japan's intangible investments into a dynamic overlapping generations model. We find that the consumption tax rate required to finance increased transfers for the elderly is approximately 6 percentage points lower when accounting for intangible capital, as the enhanced capital stock boosts production and broadens the tax base. Neglecting intangible capital thus significantly overstates Japan's fiscal challenge.

Intangible Investment in Japan: A Comparison with the United States

Presented at: International Monetary Fund (2024).

Abstract: GDP measures do not incorporate all intangible investment undertaken by firms, although the importance of intangible assets has been increasingly recognized. To provide a more comprehensive picture of macroeconomic conditions, this paper measures intangible investment in Japan, including additional intangible assets that are currently under discussion for inclusion in national accounts. The findings show that intangible investment in Japan is more than twice as large as reported in current national accounts statistics, and that its ratio to GDP is increasing and exceeds that of the United States. Incorporating these additional intangible assets has significant implications for macroeconomic measurement. First, Japan's five-year GDP growth rate is estimated to increase by approximately 1 percentage point relative to the current measure, while the corresponding estimate for the United States remains largely unchanged. In addition, the impact on GDP varies substantially across industries. Finally, the estimated labor share decreases by about 4 percentage points in both countries.

Markups and Inequality in Intangible Economy

Fellowships and Awards

Dissertation Fellowship, Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis	2026
Thomas J. Sargent Dissertation Fellowship, Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco	2026
Grover & Creta Ensley Fellowship, University of Washington	2026
Steven Langton Teaching Award, University of Washington	2025
Graduate Student Presentation Award, University of Washington	2025
Jeff and Perri Roe Term Fellowship, University of Washington	2023
Graduate Teaching Assistantship, University of Washington	2022–2025
Japan-IMF Scholarship Program, International Monetary Fund	2021–2022

Research Experience

International Monetary Fund June–August 2024
Research Intern, Washington, DC

University of Minnesota March–May 2024
Research Visitor, Minneapolis, MN

Keio University June–August 2023
Visiting Researcher, Tokyo, Japan

QuantEcon February 2020–June 2021
Research Assistant, Canberra, Australia

Australian National University March–August 2018
Research Intern, Australia-Japan Research Centre, Canberra, Australia

Teaching Experience

University of Washington Summers 2023, 2024
Instructor, Ph.D. Macroeconomics Math Camp

University of Washington 2022–2025
Teaching Assistant

- Macroeconomic Analysis I (Ph.D., ECON 502), Yu-chin Chen: Fall 2023, 2024.
- Macroeconomic Analysis II (Ph.D., ECON 503), Stephen Turnovsky: Winter 2025.
- Introduction to Macroeconomics (undergraduate, ECON 201): Fall 2022; Winter and Spring 2023; Winter 2024; Spring 2025.

Professional Experience

SMBC Trust Bank April 2016–March 2018
Sales Representative, Tokyo, Japan

Rookie of the Year, 2017; second place, monthly Customer Satisfaction Award, September 2016.

Additional Information

Programming: Python, JAX, MATLAB, R, Stata, Fortran

Languages: English (fluent), Japanese (native)

Citizenship: Japan

Work Authorization: Authorized to work in the U.S.(no employer sponsorship required)